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Couple and family optimal experiences: Integrating flow theory into the relational sciences

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Abstract

Shared experiences are a fundamental aspect of couple and family life that impact both individual well-being and satisfaction with close relationships. Optimal experience, also known as *flow*, is the state of complete absorption and fulfillment experienced when engaged in an intrinsically rewarding activity. The interdisciplinary concept of flow provides a sound basis to explore optimal shared experiences. Research on flow experiences in couple and family contexts is limited, presenting a gap in the literature. This article outlines a research program integrating flow theory into the relational sciences along three lines of inquiry. First, couple/family flow requires a clear definition and theoretical framework by building upon previous scholarly work on social flow. Second, the impact of flow experiences on relational variables (e.g., relationship quality, interpersonal commitment, sexual satisfaction) requires investigation. Lastly, flow theory presents an opportunity to develop new interventions aimed at improving the experiences couples and families share together.

KEYWORDS

couple flow, family flow, optimal experience, relationship quality, shared experiences, social flow

INTRODUCTION

Substantial evidence indicates a strong association between healthy couple/family relationships and individual well-being and life satisfaction (Grevenstein et al., 2019; Thomas et al., 2017; VanderWeele, 2017). Survey data confirm that family and intimate relationships are viewed as being among the most fulfilling aspects of a person's life (Pew Research Center, 2018, 2021).

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Emerging trends in other psychological disciplines have established the importance of well-being, most notably the positive psychology movement (Gillham & Seligman, 1999; Ryan & Deci, 2001).

Positive psychology emerged over the past few decades and put forward the central idea that the absence of psychological distress is not equivalent to positive psychological health, with healthy relationships being a core component of well-being (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). This approach contends that well-being is achieved when individuals foster meaning, purpose and virtue in their lives enabling them to achieve *eudaimonia* or human flourishing (Ryan & Deci, 2001; Ryff & Singer, 2008). Seligman (2011) proposed a positive psychology model identifying five foundational elements of well-being: positive emotion, engagement, relationships, meaning, and accomplishment. Positive relationships are an important contributor to well-being and significant research supports this contention (Keyes, 2002; Ryff, 2014; Segrin & Taylor, 2007). Hence, positive psychology has been applied in family contexts to develop programs targeting improved student success (Sheridan et al., 2004), and stronger family relationships (von Kraemer et al., 2023; Waters, 2020).

From a family systems perspective, Walsh (2002) noted that the field of family therapy was shifting toward focusing on family strengths and developed a framework based on family resilience. This approach involves guiding families to develop and harness potential resources and skills (e.g., meaning-making, fostering a positive outlook, utilizing social networks, and engaging in emotional sharing) toward effectively managing and overcoming the stressors arising from various systemic and developmental challenges (Walsh, 2012). While family studies scholars have noted the negativity bias in intimate relationship research (e.g., Fincham & Beach, 2010a), strengths-based approaches in couples therapy have also gained traction utilizing similar resilience-based tools (Benson et al., 2012). From different disciplines, these approaches to promoting healthy relationships converge on a single point of clinical focus: build up potential strengths to improve positive outcomes.

A strengths-based approach aimed at promoting healthy relationships must consider the role of shared positive experiences. Evidence suggests that positive shared experiences may contribute to relationship connectedness and well-being and yet research in this area has been limited (Algoe, 2019; Reis & Gable, 2003). *Flow*, also known as optimal experience, is a specific type of positive experience that is characterized by deep absorption and enjoyment when engaged in a meaningful activity, and also occurs in shared social situations (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990).

The phenomenon of flow experiences has been widely studied and is well-established in the research literature going back several decades (Nakamura & Csikszentmihalyi, 2016). However, little attention has been paid to flow experiences shared between couples and families. In this article, I address this gap by introducing the concept of flow, describing the considerable research basis behind flow theory, demonstrating how flow has been, and can still be, applied to couples and families. I propose to integrate flow theory into the relational sciences through investigating how couple and family flow experiences may impact indicators of relationship quality. Lastly, I discuss emerging applications of flow theory in clinical settings and explore their potential use with couples and families.

INTRODUCING FLOW

Flow is the subjective experience of being ultimately fulfilled and engaged in an intrinsically rewarding activity (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). Csikszentmihalyi (1975) initially developed the concept of flow through studying student artists and later investigations on flow experiences broadened to include amateur rock climbers, chess players, basketball athletes, dancers, and composers. In subsequent decades, flow experiences have been investigated in a diverse range of

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contexts such as: teaching professionals (Bassi & Delle Fave, 2012), sports performance (Stoll & Ufer, 2021), young musicians (Sinnamon et al., 2012), educational gaming (Bressler & Bodzin, 2016), and viewing short online videos (Zheng, 2023). Flow experiences have been found to be associated with specific individual-level factors such as personality traits and intrinsic motivation (Ullén et al., 2012; Ullén et al., 2016). Additionally, evidence suggests that flow is associated with positive individual self-evaluative factors such as: subjective well-being (Fullagar & Kelloway, 2009; Ilies et al., 2017; Lynch & Troy, 2021), sense of meaning and purpose in life (Waterman, 1993), and personal self-efficacy at work (Salanova et al., 2006).

This extensive, and continually progressing, body of research has established and validated two foundational elements of the flow experience framework: (a) flow experiences have distinctive experiential characteristics, and (b) flow state only arises when certain perceptual and activity-related prerequisites are present (Abuhamdeh, 2020; Nakamura & Csikszentmihalyi, 2016). The common experiential elements of flow reported by participants include: (a) feeling so immersed in an activity that their awareness was only occupied by what they were doing and nothing else, (b) feeling completely in control of what they were doing without any sense of concern or worry, (c) experiencing loss of self-consciousness or having no ego-based feeling of worry or concern about self, and (d) experiencing the passage of time differently; either time was felt to go by extremely quickly or, in moments of particular importance or challenge, time was experienced as having slowed down dramatically (Nakamura & Csikszentmihalyi, 2016). Additionally, there are necessary conditions that must be present in order for participants to enter the flow state when engaging in a given activity. These prerequisites for individuals to experience flow include: (a) perceiving the activity engaged in to be challenging yet within their range of competence, (b) the activity provides consistent feedback to the participant based on (c) clear and specific goals that are intrinsic to the activity, (d) the activity requires total concentration to be engaged in, and lastly (e) the activity is intrinsically rewarding and undertaken with no external goal or reward in mind (Csikszentmihalyi, 1975, 1990; Csikszentmihalyi & Csikszentmihalyi, 1988). These experiential and conditional elements of flow have allowed researchers to use varying methods to assess and measure flow experiences.

Measuring the flow experience

Csikszentmihalyi's (1975) pioneering study of flow experiences in amateur hobbyists and skilled professionals utilized both qualitative approaches (e.g., semi-structured interviews) and quantitative methods (e.g., self-report surveys) to clarify the contours of flow theory. This mixed methods approach set the stage for future researchers to use a variety of approaches to further investigate flow. Among the earliest approaches were the qualitative Flow Questionnaire (Csikszentmihalyi & Csikszentmihalyi, 1988) and the phenomenological Experience Sampling Method (ESM; Csikszentmihalyi & Larson, 1987). In the Flow Questionnaire approach, participants are asked to read a composite description of a typical flow experiences after which a semi-structured interview is conducted inquiring as to whether participants had similar experiences and the nature of those experiences (Moneta, 2012). The ESM approach involves electronically notifying study participants at several random points during the study period whereby participants then immediately complete a questionnaire detailing the nature of their current activity and describing their own psychological state on various measures such as affect, motivation, concentration, and engagement (Hektner et al., 2007). These research methods aimed to understand and assess the flow experiences of individuals through both real-time and retrospective self-reports.

More recently, self-report survey measures have been utilized to measure flow experiences in various contexts and have demonstrated appropriate psychometric properties (Moneta, 2012). Typically, these measures assess the presence of flow conditions and the phenomenological

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elements of flow, as experienced by participants when recalling their engagement in a particular activity. For example, the Flow State Scale-2 (FSS-2; Jackson & Eklund, 2002) assesses the experiential elements of flow with items such as: "I felt like I could control what I was doing" and "The way time passed seemed to be different from normal"; conditional elements of flow are assessed with items such as: "I was challenged but I believed my skills would allow me to meet the challenge" and "It was no effort to keep my mind on what was happening" (Lee-Shi & Ley, 2022, para. 2). The FSS-2, and other similar flow scales, have been validated and utilized in numerous flow investigations across multiple domains of activity demonstrating their broad applicability (e.g., see de Moura Jr & Porto Bellini, 2020; Martin & Jackson, 2008). However, self-report measures have differed in terms of how flow is operationalized; some studies have included measures that address both prerequisite and experiential aspects of flow while others include only flow prerequisite measures even though fulfilling the prerequisites of flow does not guarantee a flow experience (Engeser & Rheinberg, 2008; Lee-Shi & Ley, 2022; Moneta, 2012). Despite these differences, flow scales remain a widely used and effective tool to understand flow experiences and have been adapted for appropriate use in multiple contexts (Ottiger et al., 2021; Riva et al., 2017; Tan & Sin, 2021).

A universal experience

The concept of flow garnered international interest soon after development, and subsequently flow experiences have been identified and investigated in several different cultural contexts. In one of the earliest collections of studies on flow (Csikszentmihalyi & Csikszentmihalyi, 1988), Massimini et al. (1988) administered the Flow Questionnaire to Navajo college students in Arizona, Thai university students, and Italians of different social strata including students, workers, rural mountain community members, blind religious persons, and formerly drug addicted persons. An overwhelming majority in all participant samples reported experiences similar to being in flow state and described their experiences in similar terms to the experiential characteristics and conditions predicted by flow theory. In the same volume, Sato (1988) qualitatively investigated the emergence of Japanese biker gangs and bikers' riding experiences. The researcher found that, rather than just simply an outlet for disillusioned young men, bikers experienced flow during their collective bike runs and so argued that biker gang culture was better conceptualized as a hobby developed around a collective flow activity (Sato, 1988). Additionally, Han (1988) found a significant association between life satisfaction and frequency of flow experience among elderly Korean immigrants, which is a result predicted by flow theory.

Other cross-cultural investigations have compared the optimal experiences of American high school students to Italian high school students (Carli et al., 1988) and Hong Kong Chinese college students (Moneta, 2004). Some cultural variations were found in the Chinese participants, who demonstrated highest intrinsic motivation in situations more associated with control and boredom by flow theory (high skill, low challenge); these differences were hypothesized to be partially due to broader cultural and individual personality factors (Moneta, 2004). More recently, cross-cultural studies have replicated the association between flow experiences and subjective well-being in Japanese college students (Asakawa, 2010), Chinese university students (Wu et al., 2021), and Italian teenagers (Bassi et al., 2014).

These cross-cultural studies have identified a common experience characterized by complete absorption, concentration, and engagement in a challenging and intrinsically rewarding activity that results in feelings of ultimate fulfillment (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990; Csikszentmihalyi & Asakawa, 2016). Hence, flow can be reasonably considered as a universal human phenomenon with possible secondary differences due to socio-cultural and individual-level factors. Relatedly, scholars have also considered the role of immediate social context on flow experiences but have found it challenging to integrate group contexts into established flow theory.

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The flow of shared experiences

The experience of flow was initially considered an individual phenomenon and hence studies focused mostly on individual experiences in varying contexts (e.g., Csikszentmihalyi & Csikszentmihalyi, 1988). However, early flow researchers did note the potential for flow in social situations (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). Empirical evidence suggests that social flow is indeed distinct from individual flow. Walker (2010) found that study participants reported having more flow experiences socially than individually, and that social flow was more enjoyable than individual flow; additionally, participants who engaged in a more complex and socially interdependent sporting game experienced more joy than those who engaged in a less complex and interdependent version of the same game. Salanova et al. (2014) divided students into small groups to complete a group project and found that a group's belief in their own competence and ability to succeed at the project (collective efficacy) predicted higher levels of group-level flow experienced. Bakker et al. (2011) investigated team performance and individual flow among young Dutch soccer players and found that team performance positively predicted individual player flow experiences. These, and other studies, provide substantive indications that group-level factors affect the experience of flow in social situations.

Scholars have approached the study and conceptualization of flow in social situations through specific domains, including creative group performers (Sawyer, 2003), daily and sporting activities (Walker, 2010), teaching cohorts (Salanova et al., 2006), and work teams (van den Hout et al., 2018). This diversity of approach has resulted in multiple terms describing the same phenomenon (e.g., group flow, social flow, team flow etc.) along with slightly different conceptualizations of the phenomenon (van den Hout et al., 2018). Initially, Sawyer (2003) developed the concept of group flow by broadening the flow concept to the group level through studying creative groups such as jazz bands and improv theater groups. These creative groups perform at their best by mirroring, engaging with, and feeding off each other spontaneously during a performance, which is described as the process of "interactional synchrony" (Sawyer, 2003, p. 37). When engaged in these harmonious interactions during performances, performers often described their experiences as being in flow state. Sawyer (2003) determined that these harmonious interactions, balancing spontaneity and predictability, allowed the emergence of group flow, which is often observed when a group is "in-sync" having "good chemistry" that allows them to perform together at their best (p. 43). Lastly, Sawyer (2006) held that group flow was solely a group attribute and that it was possible for a group to be in flow while its individual members were not experiencing flow state. On this last point, later researchers have differed with Sawyer, with most holding that group-level flow necessarily results or includes individual experiences of flow (c.f. Van den Hout et al., 2018).

Social flow is a new aspect of flow theory that requires more theoretical and empirical investigation. However, flow scholars are coalescing around a framework of social flow that mirrors traditional individual-level flow theory. These approaches take the established individual-level flow conditions, processes and outcomes, and transform them into similar conditions and processes that are inherently social in nature (e.g., van den Hout et al., 2018; Walker, 2021). For example, individual-level flow requires that the activity engaged in provide clear and consistent feedback to the individual based on the clear goals of the activity (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). In the context of social flow this feedback/clear goals requirement transforms into the need for group members to: (a) pay attention to each other in order to receive feedback from each other and the task itself and (b) put the goals of the group first (Walker, 2021). Walker (2021) used a social psychology perspective to define social flow as a shared experience that arises from shared group purposes, processes, and collaborative mechanisms and suggested that a group-first attitude is an important condition for social flow, along with group tasks requiring interdependence, and a matching between group members skills and task challenges. Additionally, social flow is hypothesized to result in an increased sense of belonging to the group, strong

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positive emotions, and an outstanding group-level performance (Walker, 2021). These consequences of shared flow may be more evident in a specific social environment—the family context.

Family flow

The experience of flow in families may have significant implications for psychological well-being. Scholars of flow historically focused on how the early family environment contributes to the ability of younger family members to experience flow during childhood and, later, as adults. Rathunde (1988, 1989) posited that certain characteristics in early family life create the conditions for experiencing flow. A household where family rules are clear allows adolescents the psychological freedom to fully concentrate and immerse themselves in activities (Rathunde, 1988). Using the ESM method, experiences of adolescents were studied and it was found that adolescents from households that create conditions for flow experiences had higher quality experiences when with their families, studying on their own, and at school than adolescents in non-flow creating households (Rathunde, 1988). Rathunde (1988) attributed this finding to the development of flow prerequisites in the home that allowed certain adolescents to have higher quality experiences than others: "An autotelic family context—one that structures the child's subjective experience with a balance of choice, clarity, centering, commitment and challenge—consistently facilitates the optimal experience of adolescents" (p. 358).

Rathunde and Csikszentmihalyi (1991) found that adolescents in families that balanced family togetherness with individual autonomy—termed "complex families" (p. 144) because they rate highly in both integration and differentiation—reported greater happiness in going about day-to-day tasks at home. The terms integration and differentiation in the flow literature used here bear a striking similarity to family systems concepts of fusion and differentiation-of-self described by Bowen (1978). Using a modified ESM family interview approach, families with adolescents who demonstrated higher levels of integration and differentiation, measured by observed complex communication when discussing challenging topics, were found to experience higher levels of optimal experience defined as arousal of interest and flow experience (Rathunde, 1997).

Family context as it relates to perceived parenting styles may also be an important factor in the experience of flow. In a longitudinal study of adolescents, Rathunde (2001) found that adolescents raised in parenting contexts involving both high support (love) and high challenge (discipline) spent more time in a flow-like state termed "undivided interest," which was also associated with higher levels of undivided interest years later (p. 168). Further qualitative research has shown that certain family rules, behaviors, and attitudes enacted in complex families may contribute to the development of increased creative abilities among adults who grow up in such households (Gute et al., 2008). Complex families, and the autotelic family environments they create, may be essential to the development of a complex person—that is an individual who is capable of engaging in voluntary, self-directed play with undivided interest that allows for the continued renewal and growth of the individual; family environments can allow this development through ensuring secure attachment and engaging children in an appropriately challenging learning environment through: consistently providing comfort and stimulation, balancing support and challenge, guided participation, and engaging in discovered play (Rathunde and Csikszentmihalyi, 1991).

Family participation in shared activities that promote enjoyable engagement may enhance family functioning, improve family relationships, and increase overall family life satisfaction (Agate et al., 2009; Crespo et al., 2011). Family vacations are one such joint activity. Kirkegaard Larsen (2013) investigated flow in the context of family holidays; families often structure their vacation experience in a manner where each individual can fulfill their own needs

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of either relaxation or excitement while maintaining the sense of family togetherness and unity of experience. This joint interdependent experience where individual members also engage in optimal experiences for themselves results in a family system level balance described as "family flow" (Kirkegaard Larsen, 2013, p. 171). These family flow experiences include both individual optimal experiences set in the family context and social flow experiences resulting from joint family activities (Kirkegaard Larsen, 2013). Similarly, family experiences while traveling may also create special memories tied to shared flow experiences.

DeMatos et al. (2023) investigated the association between satisfaction with tourism travels and flow experiences; they found that flow experiences were associated with the creation of unique and memorable traveling experiences. Interestingly, and perhaps tellingly, their study did not investigate the role played by traveling companions in these touristic flow experiences; half of the study participants experienced these memorable tourist experiences with their family members, and yet the role of familial interaction and sharing of family experience was not considered in this study. It is possible that having family members as traveling companions was a crucial aspect of experiencing flow during the participants' travels. This gap points to the necessity of considering families as a particular form of social context that informs and impacts the nature of flow experiences.

Families are social units whose interactional dynamics may impact the experience of flow similar to other social contexts such as project groups, sports teams etc. Family flow research has focused on the mechanisms by which certain family environments can promote an individual's capacity to engage in flow and create shared flow experiences in family settings. Csikszentmihalyi (1990) noted that family life is our first, and often most profound, social context and which, with conscious cultivation, can itself provide the basis for many flow activities and experiences. However, the impact of these family flow experiences on overall family functioning and closeness remains unclear. Similarly, few studies have attempted to study how family environments or flow experiences impact relationship quality in committed romantic relationships.

Flow of intimate relationships

Intimate relationships involve a variety of shared experiences that impact the trajectory and quality of the lives involved. These shared experiences are essential to the development of couple relationships as they facilitate the construction of a joint understanding of the world, which allows the individuals involved to move through a shared life together (Rossignac-Milon & Higgins, 2018). Conjoint participation in new and exciting experiences has also been found to be associated with improved couples' relational satisfaction (Aron et al., 2000). Additionally, clinical interventions aimed at having married couples recall and discuss their most important shared experiences have been found to significantly improve marital satisfaction (Majzoobi & Forstmeier, 2022). Hence, couple flow, as an especially positive form of shared experience, might also be expected to have an impact on relational well-being.

Graham (2008) investigated the application of flow theory to intimate relationships through the self-expansion framework. The self-expansion model posits that individuals are intrinsically motivated to expand their own sense of self, abilities, and competencies by engaging in new or challenging activities in order to potentially increase access to resources and perspectives that better ensure achievement of goals such as survival and well-being (Aron et al., 2013). Engaging in self-expansion activities results in subjective experiences of arousal, exhilaration, and activation, which closely mirror the description of flow experiences (Graham, 2008).

Graham (2008) utilized the ESM approach to investigate the association between the flow-like experiences that arise from self-expansion activities and found that higher levels of flow-like experiences were associated with (a) increased levels of momentary relationship quality and

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(b) higher overall relationship quality, when the flow-like experiences occurred in the presence of a long-term partner. In a series of studies aiming to further integrate flow theory and the self-expansion model, Graham and Harf (2014) investigated the challenge-skill balance prerequisite condition for experiencing flow and its impact on relationship quality; couples who together engaged in challenging activities that relatively matched the skills possessed (the challenge-skill balance flow prerequisite) were more likely to report higher relationship quality and greater positive affect immediately post-activity. However, none of these studies assessed flow experience directly but instead relied on proxy measures.

Couple flow experiences may also be an important aspect of healthy sexual activity. Intense sexual experiences can induce an altered state of consciousness, which is a state of awareness and being that is significantly different from the ordinary experience of conscious life (Tart, 1971). Some research has identified that the most enjoyable and intense sexual experiences tend to be characterized by experiential elements that overlap with the flow experience. For example, Costa et al. (2016) found that, during participants' last sexual experience, sexual desire, arousal, and satisfaction were positively associated with increased bodily awareness, experiencing time passing faster, and a reduced general awareness of the passage of time. Similarly, Holbrook (2008) studied a small number of participants who described themselves as having engaged in a "transcendent sexual experience" (p. 58) and found several common experiential elements that match the flow experience: loss of control, greater sense of meaning, and again, a changed perception of time. Lastly, and most directly, Jamea et al. (2021) found that more flow experienced during sexual activity positively predicted sexual satisfaction among monogamous couples in long term relationships. This emerging body of literature suggests that couple flow experiences, including during sexual intimacy, may play an important role in understanding positive relationship health.

FUTURE AREAS OF EXPLORATION

The concept of flow provides an alternate line of inquiry that may contribute significantly to our understanding of relational well-being, both theoretically and clinically. Flow experiences in close relationship settings have historically been less explored possibly due to the lack of interdisciplinary approaches that allow for nonsystemic theories to be applied to family dynamics, as well as an overall lack of awareness regarding the relevance of flow experiences to relational contexts. A comprehensive research agenda will allow for a coherent investigation of the phenomenon of shared optimal experiences by outlining specific research objectives, areas of exploration, and methodologies, which will contribute to theoretical and clinical understandings of family, and intimate relationship, well-being. The investigation and application of flow theory to the relational sciences can be differentiated into three levels of approach: theoretical integration, relational factors, and clinical interventions.

Theoretical integration

As noted earlier, flow in social situations has been investigated in specific contexts (e.g., jazz musicians; Sawyer, 2003) or discussed conceptually (Walker, 2021). Established research on individual-level flow has identified the specific conditions for experiencing flow and the experiential indicators of flow (Nakamura & Csikszentmihalyi, 2016). Walker (2021) proposed a social flow framework informed by insights from social psychology's understanding of group dynamics. However, none of these group flow conceptualizations have been adapted to the specific context of familial or intimate relationships. The unique and important nature of familial and intimate relationships requires a focused approach to establish a coherent theory of couple/

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family flow, both theoretically and empirically. Developing a theoretical framework for couple/family flow will require incorporating the unique dynamics of family systems along broader social flow processes.

Emotional contagion is a social process that refers to the empathetic reflecting and sharing of emotional states between individuals, which grows stronger through repeated interactions (Hatfield et al., 1992, 1993). Family relationships naturally evoke heightened empathy over numerous repeated interactions, and so emotional contagion may be a particularly powerful process influencing familial shared experiences. Scholars have suggested that emotional contagion is an important process that allows for sharing of the flow experience in social and performance settings (Sawyer, 2003; Walker, 2021); some empirical evidence in musical education and general classroom environments supports this claim (Bakker, 2005; Culbertson et al., 2015). Additionally, emotional contagion has also been found to be an important systemic process in developing the therapeutic alliance in family therapy (Kivlighan et al., 2022). Along with emotional contagion, other family systems concepts may help provide a theoretical foundation for understanding and explaining optimal experiences in couples and families.

A couple/family flow framework must first begin with establishing a definition of couple/family flow experiences. This definition would include identifying: (a) the necessary experiential elements of couple/family flow, (b) the conditions required to allow for couple/family flow to be experienced, (c) the boundaries that distinguish couple/family flow from both individual flow and social flow that is not familial or couple-based in nature, and (d) the unique couple/family processes that induce flow in the relational system. Walker (2021) developed a conceptual framework for understanding social flow, which could be used as a starting point for constructing a theory of couple/family flow. However, more qualitative studies are needed to investigate and identify the elements of flow experiences in the specific couple and familial contexts.

Building on this theoretical foundation, couple/family flow research can explore the phenomenon of shared optimal experiences across various situational contexts, such as daily activities (e.g., family rituals, hobbies) and milestones events (e.g., birthdays, graduations). Investigating flow in these contexts will help identify the impact of those experiences and the meaning families construct from them. Longitudinal research will be important to track the influence of childhood flow experiences on later adult relational outcomes and shared experiences. Empirical studies will also be necessary to validate and generalize qualitative findings to broader populations. This comprehensive approach to developing a theory of couple/family flow may also involve creation of self-report scales specifically tailored to measuring couple/family flow, allowing for more precise assessment of the phenomenon.

Flow and relational factors

Shared activities and experiences that couples and families engage in impact their perception of the closeness and quality of those relationships (Agate et al., 2009; Offer, 2014). Couple and family flow, as important and positive shared experiences, may impact the quality of those relationships. Some evidence suggests that this indeed may be the case (Graham, 2008; Graham & Harf, 2014). The effects of healthier close relationships and the enhancement of relationship quality is often the core goal of theoretical research and clinical practice (Grevenstein et al., 2019; MacIntosh & Butters, 2014). Hence, in order to better understand relational well-being, the concept of relationship satisfaction must be thoroughly investigated in the context of couple and family flow experiences.

In couples contexts, shared flow experiences are the result of seamless interactional processes between members of the couple, and the activities they are engaged in, which promotes feelings of absorption, fulfillment and meaning in both partners. These shared experiences are likely to positively impact perceived relationship satisfaction. Further empirical studies are needed to confirm

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this association. Qualitative approaches may be useful in exploring the immediate and long-term impact of couple flow experiences and the relational meaning couples assign to their shared optimal experiences. Relationship satisfaction has been found to be impacted by several relational factors, including commitment, communication, conflict resolution, emotional intimacy, and support (Fincham & Beach, 2010b). Couple flow experiences may, either independently, or concurrently, have an impact on these other relational factors as well.

Commitment may be a particularly relevant factor to consider because it provides a stable framework for interpersonal interactions over a period of time (Stanley et al., 2010). This stability creates a secure relational environment that may be more conducive to deeper interpersonal engagement. Flow is an experiential state characterized by a state of deep absorption where nothing disrupts or distracts a person from the activity engaged in or the people they are with; an individual's consciousness is completely ordered in a state described as "psychic entropy" (Csikszentmihalyi, 1988, p. 22). Hence, any interpersonal doubt or worry would serve to disrupt this state of deep absorption and this doubt may arise in the context of reduced interpersonal commitment. Can a person experience true engagement and fulfillment in their experiences with a relational partner if they have lesser commitment to their partner and their relationship, or sense that their partner is uncommitted to them? The impact of this lesser commitment may fall not just on the relationship but also the conjoint experiences of the relationship partners.

Sexual intimacy is another relevant factor that may benefit from being further investigated through the perspective of flow theory. For sexual intimacy to be an optimal experience, the necessary conditions for experiencing flow would have to be met. Swartz (1994) held that sexual activity requires specifically directed attention in order to build sexual arousal and enter a state of complete absorption; concurrently, flow theory would suggest that, in order to have an optimal sexual experience, individuals must immerse themselves completely in the sexual act in order to meet the total concentration prerequisite for flow. However, more investigation is needed to test for the presence of other flow prerequisite conditions in order to establish satisfying sex as a flow activity. Further exploration into the impact of optimal sexual experiences may be warranted as substantial research has repeatedly found positive associations between sexual satisfaction and overall relationship satisfaction (Sprecher et al., 2018). Both qualitative and quantitative approaches will be necessary to investigate the impact of these interpersonal and relational variables on shared optimal experiences. The possibility that these relational variables mediate an association between relationship quality and couple flow experiences must also be considered.

As shared experiences play an important role in family life, family flow experiences may impact the closeness and quality of family relationships. These experiences may allow for younger family members to develop an increased ability to experience flow and may even enhance creativity (Gute et al., 2008; Rathunde, 2001). Hence, further research is needed to explore whether the frequency and quality of family flow improves family closeness and functioning. While shared enjoyable experiences have been identified as playing an important role in family life satisfaction, it is unclear how the nature or quality of those experiences impact family functioning. Current approaches to assess family closeness and family functioning rely on either directly assessing, through observation or self-report, family connectedness, adaptability, communication skills and interaction patterns (e.g., the Family Adaptability and Cohesion Evaluation Scale; Olson, 2011). As an interactional pattern, the role of shared optimal experiences in overall family functioning and connectedness must be evaluated.

Clinical applications of flow

Researchers have identified the potential of flow theory to impact clinical practice, and steps have been taken to apply flow theory in various disciplines (Nakamura &

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Csikszentmihalyi, 2016). Any flow theory-based intervention program will likely be interdisciplinary in nature and incorporate established theories and techniques in the specific field of application. In sporting psychology, flow state has been associated with peak performance in athletes and the impact of flow state on performance is a topic of considerable interest (Swann et al., 2012). Kaufman et al. (2009) used flow theory to assess the impact of a mindfulness-based intervention aiming to promote peak performance in athletes. The same mindfulness-based-intervention was found to improve flow state and reduce competition anxiety among amateur baseball players in Taiwan (Chen et al., 2019). Stavrou et al. (2015) utilized the flow framework, especially the challenge-skill balance flow condition, to establish a link between task orientation among athletes and propensity to experience flow in competition.

In the field of occupational therapy, the experience of flow has been found to be effective in helping patients manage the emotional distress, and high physical stress, of chronic illness. Reynolds and Prior (2006) qualitatively investigated the impact of visual art-making among women with breast cancer and found that the participants experienced flow during artistic activities; additionally, the participants reported that the flow experiences improved their daily life through reducing worries related to their illnesses and providing an overall sense of feeling more alive. Similarly, after being diagnosed with breast cancer, Nesbit (2006) detailed her conscious cultivation of flow experiences in everyday activities in order to find fulfillment and meaning in her life post-diagnosis, as well as cope with her anxiety and uncertainty surrounding her treatment. The above applications point to the potential of flow to be used as an outcome measurement tool in the therapeutic process.

Flow theory offers a novel approach to measuring therapeutic outcomes. Flow measures have been utilized to improve programmatic commitment in individual psychiatric rehabilitation therapies and promote skill and personality development among adolescents (Riva et al., 2016). In these programs, flow measures were used to measure and assess the effectiveness of various therapeutic interventions (Riva et al., 2016). Established measures of therapeutic outcomes in couple relationships commonly focus on changes observed in or self-reports of relationship satisfaction, communication, conflict, and negative emotionality (MacIntosh & Butters, 2014), whereas family measures typically focus on changes in family connectedness, adaptability, communication, and conflictual interactions (Olson, 2011; Stratton et al., 2010). Flow theory offers a simple and well-being focused approach to measuring relational therapeutic progress by focusing on quality, meaningful interactions. These flow-based assessments would revolve around a single important question: to what extent did the clinical intervention improve the quantity and quality of time spent with family members or intimate partners in a state of absorbed meaningful engagement? This approach assumes that an important aspect of the therapeutic process is to enable, and improve, an individual's ability to experience a sense of engaged joy with their loved ones. However, these flow-based measurements must be paired with specific clinical interventions targeting an increased capability to experience flow. Early scholars of flow theory noted the potential of optimal experiences to address psychological distress as well as promote overall well-being yet systematic development and implementation of flow-based programs has been uneven (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990; Nakamura & Csikszentmihalyi, 2016). Perhaps due to its positive connotations, flow theory was not considered as applicable to clinical settings but that is now changing with flow scholars in Italy leading the way.

Riva and various colleagues (2014, 2016) utilized existing concepts in psychotherapy to demonstrate the clinical applicability of flow theory; they propose that flow be considered as an experiential intervention to be consciously cultivated in therapy sessions, and also regarded flow as a skill that can be developed through behavioral interventions. Riva et al. (2014) describe flow theory's potential for promoting intrapsychic growth and put forward a series of clinical steps to improve client's well-being and their potential for experiencing more flow in their daily lives. First, clinicians must elicit from clients past optimal experiences and allow clients to

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develop an understanding of flow that is unique to their own lived experience. Next, clinicians develop a client's "Flow Profile" (p. 84), which are the general conditions and features in which the client tends to experience flow. Lastly, the clinician encourages the client to identify, and engage in, activities and situations that will allow the client to develop their capacity to experience flow. Interestingly, the authors note the potential for a deep therapeutic relationship to create a shared flow experience, which promotes the client's well-being and provides a blueprint for creating flow in their own daily lives (Riva et al., 2014).

Burt and Gonzalez (2021) make a connection between flow theory and existential-humanistic approaches to counseling by noting their similar emphasis on intrinsic meaning as a bulwark against life's unavoidable sufferings; in the case of flow theory, intrinsically meaningful activities provide immense fulfillment while, in the case of existential-humanistic thought, these activities help the individual develop their authentic self and find the unique meaning of their own life. Adding a self-of-the-therapist perspective, the authors argue that clinicians need to delve into their own optimal experiences in order to utilize flow theory as an effective tool with their own clients (Burt & Gonzalez, 2021). Similarly, Dieser et al. (2015) encouraged clinicians to understand the difference between casual leisure, which results in temporary pleasure, and serious leisure that promotes flow experiences and other long-term psychological benefits; they argue that this understanding will enable clinicians to help clients engage in hobbies and recreational activities that promote flow state and overall well-being.

Similar experiential and existential approaches to promote flow can be applied in couple/family contexts. Relational interventions based on flow theory may include creating behavioral and psychoeducational interventions designed to increase the frequency of client's engagement in shared optimal experiences. The most direct approach to clinically incorporating flow theory may revolve around developing experiential techniques that induce the state of flow in couples and families paired with psychoeducation to teach couples and families how to create shared flow experiences from themselves. Assisting couples and families in developing shared meaning and purpose may foster an improved capacity to engage in these shared optimal experiences outside of the therapeutic context. However, flow-based interventions can only become a viable therapeutic option if situated within a broader framework that integrates flow theory into the relational sciences.

Challenges

Investigating flow in couple and family contexts may be a complicated endeavor given the individualistic nature of the phenomenon and the lack of an established framework for understanding flow in group settings. Defining couple and family flow is essential yet may be perhaps the most difficult aspect of extending flow to both relational theories and clinical settings, as even the broader concept of social flow has not been fully developed and validated. These shared optimal experiences may be challenging to qualitatively investigate and measure empirically due to the complexity of family relationships, which involve multiple subjective perspectives and interacting variables.

The development of flow theory itself was a mixed methods endeavor with numerous studies combining semi-structured interviews with self-report questionnaires (Moneta, 2012). However, this approach was focused on the individual as they experienced flow during specific activities, which created challenges when applied to flow in group settings. Measuring the flow experiences of couples and families using similar methods may not fully capture the social and familial context of their experiences. Additionally, these approaches rely on participants' retrospective recollection of memories, which may be skewed by current perceptions of their relationships (Zygar-Hoffmann & Schönbrodt, 2020). Observational approaches may allow for the direct study of family flow experiences in action but would be limited by subjective

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perceptions and interpretations of the observing researcher. Hence, accurately measuring couple/family flow presents another considerable challenge that must be addressed in order to incorporate these experiences into general flow theory and family science. The history of flow theory is one of innovation and interdisciplinary collaboration; this same spirit will be required to meet these challenges.

CONCLUSION

The interdisciplinary concept of flow provides a sound theoretical basis to explore the impact of optimal experiences on familial and intimate relationships. This article proposes a research program aimed at developing a coherent theory of couple/family flow by addressing critical and unexplored questions, such as the impact of couple-based flow on relationship quality. Exploring the relational impact of shared optimal experiences and investigating clinical applications will open up new lines of inquiry across multiple disciplines seeking to improve the nature of close relationships in clinical and practical settings. These investigations will require innovative approaches to identifying and measuring couple and family flow experiences. Integrating flow theory with the relational sciences may allow for a shift toward emphasizing the positive aspects of close relationships thus expanding our understanding of what makes intimate and familial relationships engaging, fulfilling, and meaningful.

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